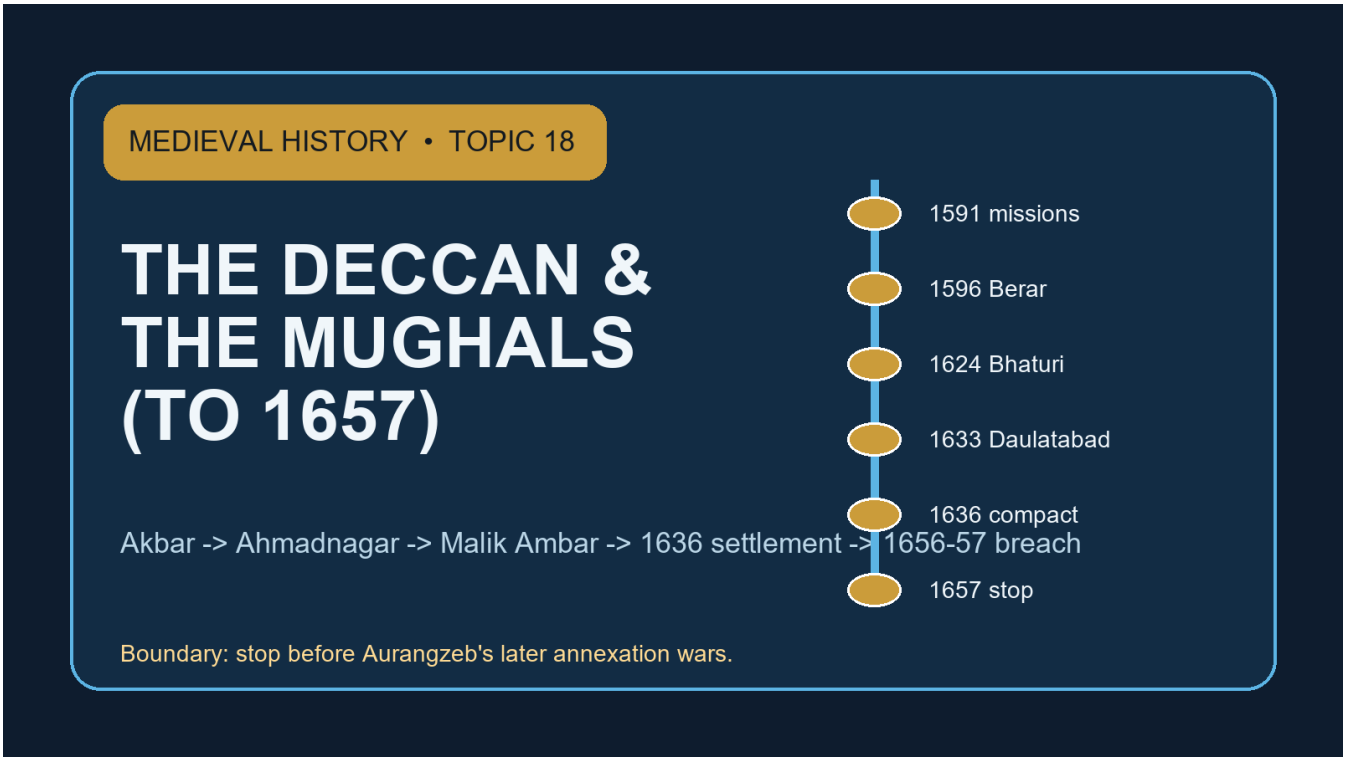
COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

The Deccan & the Mughals (to 1657) - Learner-v2 Repaired

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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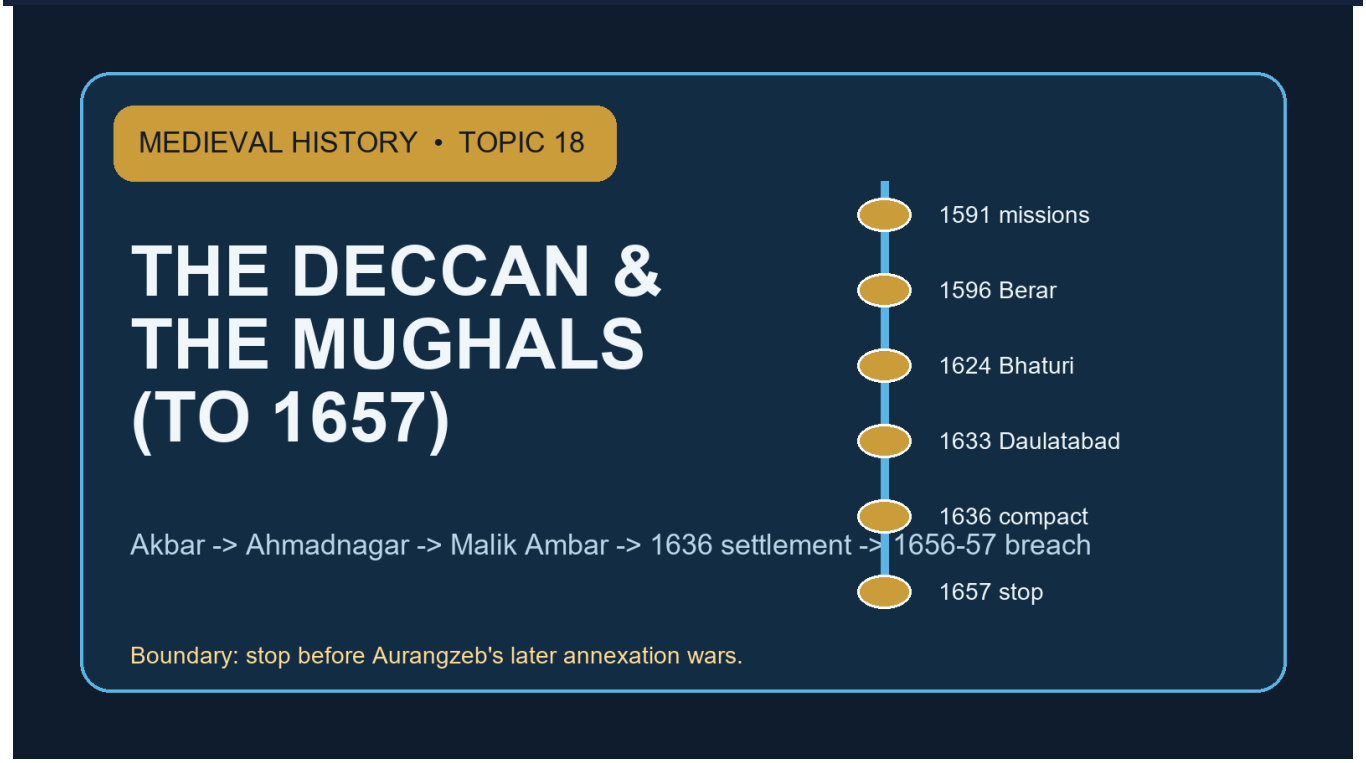
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The Deccan & the Mughals (to 1657) - Complete Topic Package



Topic 18 cover

> **Subject:** Medieval Indian History | **GS-I + Prelims** | **Repair date:** 20 September 2026 **Boundary:** Mughal-Deccan relations from Akbar's opening to the settlements of **1657**. Stop before the later annexation wars of Aurangzeb.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

SESSION 1 - TOPIC BOUNDARY, POST-BAHMANI FIELD AND A CONNECTED DECCAN

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: This topic studies how the Mughals entered the Deccan political field and managed it up to 1657, not the full Bahmani-Vijayanagara background and not the later Mughal-Maratha endgame.

Technical definition: The examinable unit is a connected but frictional Deccan: Ahmadnagar, Bijapur and Golconda as principal powers, Khandesh as gateway, and Vijayanagara/Talikota as bounded prior context already owned by Topic 09.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> Write the Deccan here as a connected field of states, routes, forts and service elites, then stop the narrative at 1657.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **post-Bahmani field**
- **Ahmadnagar**
- **Bijapur**
- **Golconda**
- **1657 boundary**

How to use them: Name the three principal Deccan sultanates and the 1657 stop-line in the first sentence so the examiner knows you will not drift into Topic 23.

Political field	Safe use in Topic 18	Keep out of core narrative
Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda	principal Mughal interlocutors	not full Bahmani institutional history
Bidar, absorbed Berar	secondary background	not a separate long dynasty essay
Khandesh / Burhanpur / Asirgarh	northern gateway into the plateau	not a substitute for the whole Deccan
Vijayanagara aftermath	light contextual bridge from Topic 09	not a re-teaching of Talikota depth
Later Aurangzeb wars	explicit out-of-scope consequence	do not narrate 1686-87 annexations

Session 1 visual. Topic 18 begins with the successor-state field and ends at 1657.

The Deccan was never an isolated south discovered only when Mughal armies crossed the Vindhyas. Traders, soldiers, Sufis, diplomats and revenue-seeking elites had long moved through Malwa, Khandesh, Burhanpur and the western coast. That is why Mughal intervention was possible at all.

Yet connection did not mean ease. Plateau routes, monsoon timing, fodder, forts and locally rooted landed intermediaries turned the same connected field into a difficult zone to hold. Topic 18 therefore works best when written as the history of entry, foothold, coalition, treaty and renewed pressure.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A compact introduction can claim that the Deccan in this topic is a connected but frictional political field rather than a sealed north-south divide. The named evidence is the Khandesh-Burhanpur gateway, the three principal states of Ahmadnagar, Bijapur and Golconda, and the repeated importance of forts and supply. The analysis is that Mughal entry became possible because the field was connected, while durable control stayed difficult because routes, ecology and local elites mattered. The qualification is the boundary itself: stop at 1657 and do not import Aurangzeb's later annexation wars as completed facts.

UPSC trap: Do not reopen the full Bahmani-Vijayanagara syllabus or slide into the 1686-87 annexations.

Mains angle: A high-scoring introduction distinguishes the Deccan field from the later full imperial war.

Study link: Use Topic 09 only for brief post-Talikota background and Topic 23 only for later consequences.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - TOPIC BOUNDARY, POST-BAHMANI FIELD AND A CONNECTED DECCAN

```
START / CONCEPT: Topic 18 boundary and Deccan field
EXACT TERMS: post-Bahmani field | Ahmadnagar | Bijapur | Golconda | 1657 boundary
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Connected routes made Mughal entry possible; frictional ecology and local
politics made consolidation expensive.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Topic 18 ends at 1657; later annexation belongs elsewhere.
```

SESSION 2 - KHANDESH, SUZERAINTY AND WHY THE MUGHALS MOVED SOUTH

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Mughal move south began with a gateway problem and an over-lordship claim, not with instant desire to annex every Deccan state at once.

Technical definition: Akbar's Deccan logic joined all-India sovereignty, the Khandesh-Burhanpur-Asirgarh corridor, Deccani instability, revenue and trade considerations, and Portuguese pressure on western seaborne movement.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> Akbar moved south first through Khandesh and the language of suzerainty, not by beginning with universal direct annexation.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Khandesh gateway**

- **Burhanpur**
- **Asirgarh**
- **suzerainty**
- **Portuguese context**

How to use them: Use Khandesh and suzerainty together: the first gives geography, the second gives policy vocabulary.

```
Malwa/Gujarat consolidation
        -> Khandesh gateway secured
        -> Burhanpur/Asirgarh staging and route control
        -> pressure on Deccan rulers for submission
        -> force only when diplomacy fails or crisis opens a door
```

Session 2 visual. Route control and hierarchy explain why Khandesh mattered.

Khandesh mattered because Burhanpur linked the Agra-Surat line with the plateau approach, while Asirgarh guarded access. A Mughal emperor interested in the Deccan had to think first about corridors, stores, fort staging and communication.

Policy language matters just as much. Tribute, alliance, protection, suzerainty and annexation are not synonyms. Akbar's preferred first move resembled the Rajasthan pattern: accept Mughal superiority, maintain order and serve the emperor, while preserving a local court.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A strong analytical paragraph can argue that Khandesh turned Mughal ambition into a practicable Deccan policy because route control and hierarchy worked together. The named evidence is Burhanpur on the route system, Asirgarh as the fort-gateway, and Akbar's preference for over-lordship before direct rule. The analysis is that geography made intervention feasible while suzerainty reduced the immediate cost of full annexation. The qualification is that diplomacy did not equal equality: embassies carried warning and demand alongside negotiation.

UPSC trap: Do not treat Khandesh as one of the Bahmani successor states or suzerainty as the same thing as annexation.

Mains angle: This session frames Mughal policy as graded hierarchy rather than a modern sovereignty binary.

Study link: Topic 19 owns Safavid-Central Asian foreign policy; Topic 18 uses only the Deccan corridor logic.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - KHANDESH, SUZERAINTY AND WHY THE MUGHALS MOVED SOUTH

```
START / CONCEPT: Why Khandesh mattered
EXACT TERMS: Khandesh gateway | Burhanpur | Asirgarh | suzerainty | Portuguese context
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Route control through Burhanpur and Asirgarh enabled a suzerainty-first
Deccan policy.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Western-coast pressure is context, not the sole cause of every campaign.
```

SESSION 3 - THE 1591 MISSIONS AND THE AHMADNAGAR CRISIS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Before major war, Akbar tested the Deccan through embassies that asked for submission rather than through an equal diplomatic conference.

Technical definition: The 1591 missions were coercive diplomacy: Khandesh complied clearly, whereas Ahmadnagar and the other courts answered without accepting Mughal over-lordship; the later Ahmadnagar succession crisis gave intervention its opening.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> The 1591 embassies show that Mughal diplomacy in the Deccan was a demand for hierarchy, not a ceremony of interstate equality.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **1591 missions**

- **coercive diplomacy**
- **Khandesh submission**
- **Ahmadnagar crisis**
- **Burhan Nizam Shah**

How to use them: Begin with the one secure contrast-Khandesh submitted, Ahmadnagar did not-then move to the succession crisis that converted pressure into intervention.

1591 response pattern	What it means
Khandesh accepts clearly	Mughal suzerainty could work through submission
Ahmadnagar rejects sharply	diplomacy alone could not secure hierarchy
other courts send courtesy and presents	politeness did not equal submission
later succession crisis at Ahmadnagar	intervention opportunity opens

Session 3 visual. The missions matter because their responses were uneven.

The embassies of 1591 were not empty formalities. They measured willingness to recognise Mughal superiority. Khandesh complied clearly, which mattered because it turned the northern gateway into a more usable imperial base. Ahmadnagar, by contrast, refused the demand.

The real opening came when Ahmadnagar entered succession crisis after Burhan Nizam Shah's death and then Ibrahim's death in war. Mughal force now entered a crisis-ridden field rather than a settled monarchy.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

An examiner-grade paragraph can claim that the 1591 missions failed politically even before they failed militarily. The named evidence is Khandesh's acceptance, Ahmadnagar's refusal and the merely courteous responses elsewhere. The analysis is that Akbar gained information and a gateway but not the wider submission he sought, so the later succession crisis at Ahmadnagar became decisive. The qualification is that diplomacy still mattered afterward; war did not replace negotiation, it intensified it.

UPSC trap: Do not write that all Deccan rulers accepted Mughal authority in 1591.

Mains angle: This session lets you show policy evolution from embassy to intervention.

Study link: Use Topic 16 only for background on Mughal administrative capacity, not for replacing the Deccan chronology.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE 1591 MISSIONS AND THE AHMADNAGAR CRISIS

```
START / CONCEPT: 1591 missions
EXACT TERMS: 1591 missions | coercive diplomacy | Khandesh submission | Ahmadnagar crisis | Burhan
Nizam Shah
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Uneven diplomatic responses left only Khandesh securely aligned; Ahmadnagar's
internal crisis then opened the door to force.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Courtesy from Deccan courts did not amount to submission.
```

SESSION 4 - CHAND BIBI, BERAR AND THE FIRST MUGHAL FOOTHOLD

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Chand Bibi was not just a heroic defender; she was a regent trying to preserve Ahmadnagar under factional pressure by mixing resistance and negotiation.

Technical definition: In the 1595-96 Ahmadnagar crisis, Chand Bibi backed infant Bahadur, drew on Habshi support and sought Bijapur-Golconda aid; the four-month defence ended in a settlement that ceded Berar while preserving the regency under Mughal suzerainty.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> Chand Bibi matters because she turned defence, regency and negotiation into one constrained political strategy.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Chand Bibi**
- **Bahadur**
- **Berar**
- **regency**
- **Habshi backing**

How to use them: Write Chand Bibi as a political actor under constraint: defence first, then negotiated survival through Berar cession.

```
Burhan/Ibrahim deaths
      -> rival claimants and noble blocs
      -> Chand Bibi backs infant Bahadur
      -> siege and four-month defence
      -> 1596 compromise: Berar ceded + Bahadur retained + Mughal suzerainty accepted
```

Session 4 visual. The 1596 outcome was negotiated survival, not total victory for either side.

Chand Bibi's historical importance lies in the combination of military firmness and political flexibility. She defended Ahmadnagar long enough to deny the Mughals an easy capture, yet she also recognised that endless resistance without coalition support could destroy the regency she was trying to preserve.

The 1596 settlement therefore ceded Berar, recognised Bahadur under her regency and accepted Mughal suzerainty. That compromise gave the Mughals a durable foothold while leaving the Nizam Shahi court alive enough to continue contestation.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A disciplined paragraph can claim that Chand Bibi preserved Ahmadnagar politically even while conceding ground strategically. The named evidence is the four-month defence, her support for infant Bahadur and the 1596 Berar settlement. The analysis is that she traded territory for dynastic survival and time, which explains why Mughal entry deepened without immediately extinguishing the Nizam Shahi line. The qualification is that the settlement was born of compulsion and factional weakness, so it cannot be romanticised as free bargaining.

UPSC trap: Do not flatten Chand Bibi into either a pure surrender figure or a mythic lone warrior who solved the crisis single-handedly.

Mains angle: Her case lets you explain how regency, fort defence and diplomacy could coexist in one answer.

Study link: The detailed Bahmani-Vijayanagara background of Deccan coalitions remains Topic 09.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CHAND BIBI, BERAR AND THE FIRST MUGHAL FOOTHOLD

```
START / CONCEPT: Chand Bibi and Berar
EXACT TERMS: Chand Bibi | Bahadur | Berar | regency | Habshi backing
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: She used fort defence to gain a negotiated regency-saving compromise that
still gave the Mughals Berar.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The 1596 settlement preserved Ahmadnagar temporarily; it did not make the
state disappear.
```

SESSION 5 - 1600-01: AHMADNAGAR FORT, ASIRGARH AND THE LIMIT OF MAP CONQUEST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Fort captures and annexation claims gave the Mughals a major foothold, but they did not amount to automatic control of the remaining Deccan countryside.

Technical definition: The 1597 Deccani attempt to recover Berar failed; renewed siege war and factional breakdown led to Chand Bibi's murder and the fall of Ahmadnagar fort in 1600, followed by Asirgarh and Khandesh in 1601, while

a Nizam Shahi remnant still survived under Murtaza II.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> By 1601 the Mughals had forts, Berar and Khandesh; they did not yet possess a fully pacified Deccan.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **1597 Berar battle**
- **Ahmadnagar fort**
- **Asirgarh**
- **Khandesh annexation**
- **Murtaza II**

How to use them: Use fort fall and remnant survival together so the answer does not confuse a map gain with settled control.

Mughal gain by 1601	What it secured	What it still did not secure
Berar foothold	forward base and claim	automatic obedience of all Deccan states
Ahmadnagar fort	a major strategic node	extinction of Nizam Shahi legitimacy
Asirgarh + Khandesh	gateway and route control	reliable plateau-wide consolidation

Session 5 visual. A fort and a province could be won faster than a countryside.

The 1597 battle-printed in one source as Sonepat in the Berar theatre-shows the Deccani powers trying to reverse the Berar cession collectively. Their failure confirmed that the Mughal foothold was not accidental. Even so, the victory did not end the war.

The second siege of Ahmadnagar ended amid factional suspicion, Chand Bibi's death and Mughal capture of the fort in 1600. Akbar then secured Asirgarh and formally annexed Khandesh in 1601. These were serious achievements, but a Nizam Shahi remnant survived and wider consolidation remained incomplete.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A good middle paragraph can argue that Akbar won a strategic foothold, not a finished Deccan conquest. The named evidence is the 1597 defeat of the Berar recovery effort, the fall of Ahmadnagar fort in 1600 and the capture of Asirgarh with Khandesh annexation in 1601. The analysis is that the Mughals now held forts and corridors from which later campaigns could operate. The qualification is the survival of a Nizam Shahi remnant under Murtaza II, which prevents the answer from treating 1601 as complete pacification.

UPSC trap: Do not call 1600-01 the final conquest of Bijapur, Golconda and the entire Deccan.

Mains angle: This session is ideal for distinguishing battlefield success from state-building success.

Study link: Topic 21 later develops the administrative and fiscal limits of overextension; Topic 18 applies the idea first in the Deccan.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - 1600-01: AHMADNAGAR FORT, ASIRGARH AND THE LIMIT OF MAP CONQUEST

```
START / CONCEPT: 1600-01 foothold and limit
EXACT TERMS: 1597 Berar battle | Ahmadnagar fort | Asirgarh | Khandesh annexation | Murtaza II
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Fort and route gains gave the Mughals leverage, but remnant legitimacy and
countryside politics blocked full consolidation.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Annexation on paper does not equal durable local control.
```

SESSION 6 - MALIK AMBAR: ORIGIN, COALITION AND MOBILE WARFARE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Malik Ambar mattered because he turned a surviving Nizam Shahi claim into a coalition able to exploit Mughal logistical weakness.

Technical definition: An Ethiopian or Habshi figure who rose through Deccan service, Malik Ambar became the Peshwa of the restored Nizam Shahi regime and combined dynastic legitimacy, Habshi-Deccani-Afghan manpower, Bijapuri help and Maratha bargi mobility.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> Malik Ambar's achievement was not a miracle of one man alone; it was the political organisation of a mobile anti-Mughal coalition.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Malik Ambar**
- **Habshi leader**
- **Peshwa**
- **Maratha bargis**
- **supply-cutting**

How to use them: Identify Ambar by office and coalition, then explain his method through mobility and logistics rather than through myth.

```
restored Nizam Shahi claimant
        + Habshi leadership
        + Deccani/Afghan fighters
        + Bijapuri support when useful
        + Maratha bargi cavalry + deshmukh intelligence
        = resistance with mobility, not permanent unity
```

Session 6 visual. Ambar's strength lay in coalition-making plus movement.

Malik Ambar cannot be reduced either to a later nationalist hero or to a mere adventurer. The secure identification is Ethiopian/Habshi origin, rise through Deccan service and eventual leadership as Peshwa in Nizam Shahi politics.

His military significance lay in exploiting the gap between Mughal siege power and Mughal staying power. Rapid cavalry movement, harassment, plunder, intelligence gathering and the cutting of supply lines could wear down larger imperial armies that needed grain, fodder and secure routes.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A strong Malik Ambar paragraph can claim that his real innovation was operational, not merely personal. The named evidence is his position as Peshwa, the restored Nizam Shahi claimant, Bijapuri support when interests aligned and Maratha bargi mobility used against Mughal supply. The analysis is that Ambar converted a surviving dynastic cause into a logistical challenge the Mughals could not solve quickly. The qualification is that coalition politics stayed unstable; his allies were partners of opportunity, not a permanent united front.

UPSC trap: Do not label Malik Ambar a Maratha king or write his campaigns as a fully formed later nationalist war.

Mains angle: He is the best route for showing how coalition, terrain and logistics checked imperial scale.

Study link: Topic 23 later takes the Maratha state forward; Topic 18 owns only the earlier service and mobility bridge.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MALIK AMBAR: ORIGIN, COALITION AND MOBILE WARFARE

```
START / CONCEPT: Malik Ambar coalition
EXACT TERMS: Malik Ambar | Habshi leader | Peshwa | Maratha bargis | supply-cutting
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Ambar fused claimant legitimacy with mobile cavalry and local intelligence to
attack Mughal logistics.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi service is not the same thing as a later
Maratha sovereign.
```

SESSION 7 - REVENUE, KHIRKI AND WHY CONQUEST DID NOT BECOME CONSOLIDATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Deccan problem was fiscal and local as much as military: forts could fall, yet revenue, cultivation and cooperation could still fail to follow.

Technical definition: Later Marathi evidence links Malik Ambar with measurement, village boundaries, rates and a zabti-type move away from ijara, while Khirki and its water system show material support for renewed state capacity; neither point licenses claims of a uniform copied Todar Mal system.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> The safest formula is simple: Mughal siege power could seize a node, but only revenue, supply and local cooperation could turn that node into rule.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **zabti-type reform**
- **ijara**
- **Khirki**
- **jama and hasil**
- **durable control**

How to use them: Use revenue caution and local cooperation together; never claim that one administrative label solved the Deccan problem by itself.

Problem of consolidation	What looked strong	What actually had to work
siege victory	artillery and fort capture	grain, fodder, pay and communications
revenue claim	high assessed jama	actual hasil and collection
provincial order	paper assignment	local deshmukh and official cooperation
city building	Khirki and waterworks	sustained political backing

Session 7 visual. Durable control required more than a captured fort and a revenue label.

The canonical caution about Malik Ambar's revenue policy is important. Later Marathi traditions point toward measurement, village boundaries, graded rates and movement away from ijara toward a zabti-like system. That evidence is useful because it links war with agrarian reconstruction.

Still, the safe claim is not that Ambar copied Todar Mal exactly or imposed a uniform one-third assessment across the whole region. The deeper lesson is broader: in the Deccan, conquest became rule only when revenue, local staff, forts and supplies worked together.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A careful explanatory paragraph can argue that Deccan warfare repeatedly exposed the distance between assessed authority and realised control. The named evidence is the later attribution of zabti-type measures to Malik Ambar, the contrast between jama and hasil, and Khirki's association with renewed logistical capacity. The analysis is that both Mughal and Deccani power depended on agrarian recovery and local cooperation, not just on battle results. The qualification is methodological: later Marathi testimony supports a bounded claim about tendency, not a mathematically exact administrative blueprint.

UPSC trap: Avoid writing that Malik Ambar simply transplanted Todar Mal's system everywhere without qualification.

Mains angle: This session gives you the fiscal language to explain why conquest could remain chronically deficit-prone.

Study link: Topic 16 owns the full Mughal mansab-jagir framework; Topic 18 uses it only to explain Deccan strain.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - REVENUE, KHIRKI AND WHY CONQUEST DID NOT BECOME CONSOLIDATION

```
START / CONCEPT: Why conquest did not equal consolidation
EXACT TERMS: zabti-type reform | ijara | Khirki | jama and hasil | durable control
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Captured forts and assessed revenue still needed actual collection, supplies
and local cooperation to become lasting rule.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Administrative resemblance is not proof of complete administrative identity.
```

SESSION 8 - JAHANGIR, PRINCE KHURRAM AND THE MARATHA SERVICE BRIDGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Jahangir's Deccan story is not just failure; it is recovery with restraint, while Maratha service networks deepened within that contested field before Shivaji.

Technical definition: After Akbar's death and Khusrau's rebellion, Malik Ambar reversed many gains; the failed 1611 two-pronged Mughal effort was followed by recovery in 1616-17 and 1621 under Khan-i-Khanan and Prince Khurram, while Bhaturi in 1624 marked a late Ambar peak and Maratha sardars continued to shift service between states.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> Jahangir's reign recovered territory without committing to unlimited annexation, and that middle course matters as much as the battles.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **1611 failure**
- **Prince Khurram**
- **farzand**
- **Bhaturi**
- **Shahji bridge**

How to use them: Pair recovery with restraint: Mughal victories matter, but so does the decision not to widen them into total annexation.

```
1610 reversal -> 1611 failed coordination
             -> 1616 Khan-i-Khanan success
             -> 1617 Khurram pressure and restoration
             -> 1621 renewed Mughal leverage
             -> 1624 Bhaturi shows Ambar still dangerous
```

Session 8 visual. Jahangir's phase oscillated between recovery and renewed Deccani resilience.

By 1610, many Akbari gains outside secure bases had been reversed. The failed 1611 two-pronged advance showed that manpower without coordination could not solve the Deccan problem. Mughal recovery then came through better command and political recruitment.

The crucial interpretive point is Jahangir's restraint. He did not convert these successes into unlimited annexation. Calling the Adil Shah *farzand* signalled hierarchy with accommodation. This phase also matters for the pre-Shivaji Maratha bridge, because Maratha landed and military families served Ahmadnagar, Bijapur and the Mughals.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A good Jahangir paragraph can claim that Mughal recovery did not automatically harden into annexationist policy. The named evidence is the failed 1611 coordination, the gains of 1616-17 and 1621, Jahangir's restrained settlement language including *farzand*, and Bhaturi in 1624 as proof that Malik Ambar remained formidable. The analysis is that the empire could reassert hierarchy without solving the underlying cost problem. The qualification is that restraint should not be read as impotence alone; it was also a strategic choice to avoid deeper commitments.

UPSC trap: Do not write Jahangir's Deccan policy as either complete impotence or permanent peace.

Mains angle: This session gives you a balanced treatment of military success, diplomatic restraint and the Maratha service bridge.

Study link: Topic 20 owns Jahangir's wider court politics; Topic 18 owns the Deccan campaign logic.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - JAHANGIR, PRINCE KHURRAM AND THE MARATHA SERVICE BRIDGE

```
START / CONCEPT: Jahangir and the Maratha bridge
EXACT TERMS: 1611 failure | Prince Khurram | farzand | Bhaturi | Shahji bridge
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Military recovery restored leverage, but Jahangir still preferred managed
hierarchy to endless annexation.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Pre-Shivaji Maratha service is a bridge, not the later sovereign state.
```

SESSION 9 - SHAH JAHAN, FATH KHAN, DAULATABAD AND SHAHJI'S RESISTANCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Shah Jahan hardened policy against Ahmadnagar, yet even dynastic extinction did not instantly remove resistance from the field.

Technical definition: Khan-i-Jahan Lodi's rebellion and Ahmadnagar asylum, Fath Khan's political betrayal, the surrender of Daulatabad in 1633 and Shahji Bhonsale's claimant politics together explain why Shah Jahan first eliminated the Nizam Shahi line before reorganising the Deccan through treaty buffers.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> Shah Jahan solved the Ahmadnagar dynastic problem before he tried to stabilise the wider Deccan.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Khan-i-Jahan Lodi**
- **Fath Khan**
- **Daulatabad 1633**
- **Shahji Bhonsale**
- **dynastic extinction**

How to use them: Keep dynasty and resistance separate: the ruling line ended in 1633, but claimant politics and mobile resistance continued.

1629-33 sequence	Political meaning
Ahmadnagar shelters Khan-i-Jahan Lodi	Shah Jahan treats the state as intolerable
Fath Khan shifts position	internal collapse aids Mughal pressure
Daulatabad falls in 1633	ruling Nizam Shahi line ends
Shahji backs a claimant	resistance survives dynastic extinction

Session 9 visual. The dynasty ended before the field was fully pacified.

Shah Jahan's policy toward Ahmadnagar became harder than Jahangir's because an independent Nizam Shahi state still threatened Mughal Berar-Balaghat claims and offered refuge to enemies such as Khan-i-Jahan Lodi. The issue was no longer only frontier prestige; it was the persistence of a hostile neighbouring regime.

Fath Khan's betrayal accelerated Mughal success. Daulatabad surrendered in 1633 and the captive ruler was removed, ending the ruling dynasty. But Shahji kept resistance alive by backing another claimant with Bijapuri help, disbanded soldiers and local mobility.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A strong paragraph here can claim that Shah Jahan defeated the Nizam Shahi state at the dynastic level before he solved the Deccan problem at the regional level. The named evidence is Ahmadnagar's asylum to Khan-i-Jahan Lodi, Fath Khan's defection and the surrender of Daulatabad in 1633. The analysis is that the dynasty's extinction created the precondition for a new Mughal settlement. The qualification is Shahji's continuing claimant resistance, which shows why even a successful siege could not settle the field by itself.

UPSC trap: Do not say that Daulatabad's fall ended all resistance in the Deccan.

Mains angle: This session is the bridge from conquest against Ahmadnagar to the 1636 statesmanlike settlement.

Study link: Topic 21 later expands Shah Jahan's wider reign; Topic 18 keeps only the Deccan policy line.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - SHAH JAHAN, FATH KHAN, DAULATABAD AND SHAHJI'S RESISTANCE

```
START / CONCEPT: 1633 Daulatabad and Shahji
EXACT TERMS: Khan-i-Jahan Lodi | Fath Khan | Daulatabad 1633 | Shahji Bhonsale | dynastic extinction
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Shah Jahan eliminated the ruling Nizam Shahi line, but Shahji proved that
resistance could outlive dynastic extinction.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A surrendered capital is not the same thing as a fully quiet countryside.
```

SESSION 10 - THE 1636 SETTLEMENT: BIJAPUR, GOLCONDA AND SUZERAINTY WITHOUT ANNEXATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The 1636 Deccan settlement preserved Bijapur and Golconda as subordinate but autonomous courts under Mughal pressure.

Technical definition: The twin 1636 arrangements imposed separate obligations: Bijapur accepted Mughal suzerainty, indemnity, arbitration limits and Shahji-related conditions, while Golconda accepted Mughal-protective hierarchy signalled through tribute and khutba change; both illustrate coercive buffer management rather than full annexation.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> The key to 1636 is the distinction between imperial superiority and direct provincial incorporation.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **1636 ahdnamas**
- **Bijapur**
- **Golconda**
- **khutba**
- **buffer states**

How to use them: Always name the settlement as suzerainty or coercive hierarchy first, then add the specific Bijapur and Golconda terms.

1636 partner	Core obligations	Why it was not annexation
Bijapur	suzerainty, indemnity, arbitration, Shahji condition	court survived and gained territory
Golconda	khutba shift, tribute/protection, loyalty	ruler remained in place

1636 partner	Core obligations	Why it was not annexation
Mughals	direct hold over northern Deccan core	cheaper than annexing every state

Session 10 visual. The 1636 compact created a graded imperial hierarchy, not a blank map of direct rule.

The most exam-worthy distinction in Topic 18 is suzerainty versus annexation. Shah Jahan did not annex Bijapur or Golconda in 1636. Instead he created a system in which direct Mughal provinces coexisted with subordinate Deccan courts that acknowledged imperial superiority in different ways.

Satish Chandra's positive assessment of the settlement as statesmanlike rests on cost and capacity. Buffer states could preserve order more cheaply than endless occupation. That praise still needs qualification: the compact depended on continued force, compliance and trust.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

An examiner-grade paragraph can argue that the 1636 settlement matched Mughal ambition to Mughal capacity better than open-ended conquest did. The named evidence is the Bijapur indemnity and arbitration framework, the Golconda khutba change, and the survival of both courts under Mughal superiority. The analysis is that imperial hierarchy could be enforced without taking on the full administrative burden of every southern territory. The qualification is that the arrangement remained coercive and fragile; its success depended on sustained credibility rather than on one signed document alone.

UPSC trap: Never write that 1636 annexed Bijapur and Golconda outright.

Mains angle: This is the best session for explaining the difference between victory, hierarchy and governance cost.

Study link: Use Topic 09 only for the wider southern setting and Topic 21 for later ruling-class finance, not for replacing the treaty analysis.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - THE 1636 SETTLEMENT: BIJAPUR, GOLCONDA AND SUZERAINTY WITHOUT ANNEXATION

```
START / CONCEPT: 1636 suzerainty without annexation
EXACT TERMS: 1636 ahdnamas | Bijapur | Golconda | khutba | buffer states
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Mughals kept direct northern provinces while subordinating Bijapur and
Golconda as buffer courts.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Khutba or tribute alone never proves direct provincial administration.
```

SESSION 11 - AURANGZEB'S VICEROYALTIES, MIR JUMLA AND THE 1656-57 BREAKDOWN

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: By 1657 the 1636 order had been politically broken through fiscal strain, new opportunities and more demanding Mughal intervention, even though full annexation was still not completed.

Technical definition: Aurangzeb's first viceroyalty (1636-44) belonged to implementation, while the second (1652-57) faced deficit, low realisation and pressure for compensation; the Mir Jumla-Golconda rupture in 1656 and the Bijapur succession crisis of 1656-57 reopened the annexation question without yet solving the cost of direct rule.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

> The story ends not with a completed conquest but with the breakdown of a workable compact.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Aurangzeb viceroyalties**
- **Murshid Quli Khan**
- **Mir Jumla**
- **Ramgir**
- **1657 breach**

How to use them: Keep 1636-44 and 1652-57 distinct, then show how fiscal strain and opportunity reopened the Deccan question before the war of succession.

```
1636 compact implemented
     -> Deccan deficit and weak realization
     -> Aurangzeb + Murshid Quli seek relief
     -> Mir Jumla breaks with Golconda (1656)
     -> Bijapur succession crisis (1656)
     -> 1657 settlements break the spirit of 1636
     -> STOP before 1658 succession war and later annexations
```

Session 11 visual. The 1656-57 ending is a breach-point, not the later full imperial war.

Aurangzeb's first Deccan viceroyalty followed the 1636 settlement and belongs to implementation, not to later annexationist hindsight. The second viceroyalty, beginning in 1652, was different. Weak realisation from Deccan jagirs, fiscal deficit and disagreement over remedies made territorial or indemnity solutions look attractive again.

The Golconda crisis grew around Mir Jumla's rupture with the Qutb Shahi court, his Karnataka wealth and disputes over tribute and exchange. The Bijapur crisis after Muhammad Adil Shah's death in 1656 then produced further Mughal intervention, culminating in 1657 terms that compelled surrender of former Nizam Shahi lands without annexing the whole state.

PARAGRAPH DEMONSTRATION

A closing body paragraph can claim that the Deccan problem was reopened by 1657 because fiscal strain and political opportunity made limited hierarchy harder to sustain. The named evidence is Aurangzeb's second viceroyalty with Murshid Quli Khan, Mir Jumla's break with Golconda in 1656, the Ramgir settlement and the 1657 Bijapur surrender of former Nizam Shahi lands. The analysis is that Mughal intervention had moved beyond the spirit of 1636 without yet securing a viable direct-rule alternative. The qualification is the chronological boundary itself: do not narrate the succession war or the 1686-87 annexations as though Topic 18 had already reached them.

UPSC trap: Do not project the later emperor's full Deccan wars backward into the years ending in 1657.

Mains angle: This session supplies the exact bridge from Shah Jahan's settlement to the later unresolved imperial dilemma.

Study link: Topic 23 begins where this topic stops: after 1657 and into the mature Mughal-Maratha struggle.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - AURANGZEB'S VICEROYALTIES, MIR JUMLA AND THE 1656-57 BREAKDOWN

```
START / CONCEPT: 1656-57 breakdown
EXACT TERMS: Aurangzeb viceroyalties | Murshid Quli Khan | Mir Jumla | Ramgir | 1657 breach
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Fiscal weakness plus Mir Jumla and Bijapur crises broke the 1636 spirit
before full annexation became reality.
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The topic ends with breach and unresolved dilemma, not with Aurangzeb's
completed later conquests.
```

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Part I - 16 core retrieval MCQs (locked count)

Learning MCQ 1

Which statement best defines Topic 18's boundary?

- A. It covers Mughal-Deccan relations from Akbar's opening to the 1657 settlements.
- B. It narrates the later 1686-87 annexations in full.
- C. It is mainly a full Bahmani institutional history.
- D. It is a complete biography of Shivaji.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The correct answer keeps the chronology at 1657; the tempting distractor is the later-annexation option, which belongs to a later topic.

Learning MCQ 2

Why was Khandesh strategically important?

- A. It was the capital of Golconda.
- B. It linked Burhanpur and Asirgarh with the route into the plateau.
- C. It made Berar unnecessary.
- D. It was itself one of the five Bahmani successor states.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Burhanpur and Asirgarh made Khandesh a gateway; the closest distractor is the successor-state claim, which misclassifies the Faruqi polity.

Learning MCQ 3

What did the 1591 Mughal missions seek first?

- A. Equal treaties among sovereign states.
- B. Immediate annexation of every Deccan court.
- C. Recognition of Mughal over-lordship.
- D. Retreat from western-coast concerns.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The missions were coercive diplomacy for hierarchy, not instant annexation or equality.

Learning MCQ 4

Which statement about Chand Bibi is safest?

- A. She only fought and never negotiated.
- B. She ruled Bijapur after 1636.
- C. She ended all Mughal pressure permanently.
- D. She defended Ahmadnagar and accepted Berar cession to preserve Bahadur's regency.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Her importance lies in defence plus negotiated survival; the purely martial version misses the political settlement.

Learning MCQ 5

What is the most secure reading of 1600-01?

- A. The Mughals gained a foothold in Ahmadnagar and Khandesh, not the whole Deccan.
- B. All Deccan sultanates were annexed.
- C. Portuguese power on the coast disappeared.
- D. Mughal policy toward the Deccan ended.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Fort and corridor gains mattered, but a Nizam Shahi remnant survived and wider consolidation remained incomplete.

Learning MCQ 6

Malik Ambar should first be identified as

- A. a Maratha king who founded Shivaji's state.
- B. a Habshi leader and Nizam Shahi Peshwa who used a broad coalition.
- C. a Portuguese admiral at Goa.
- D. a Mughal governor of Khandesh loyal to Jahangir.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The key identifiers are Habshi origin, Nizam Shahi office and coalition politics.

Learning MCQ 7

Why is "guerrilla warfare" only a cautious label for Malik Ambar's method?

- A. Because it refers here to Atlantic naval raiding.
- B. Because Ambar refused to use intelligence or terrain.
- C. Because it names mobility and supply-cutting but should not be equated with a modern ideological insurgency.
- D. Because the Deccan had no forts.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The label is useful only if kept tied to logistics and movement rather than modern ideology.

Learning MCQ 8

What is the safest claim about Malik Ambar's revenue policy?

- A. He copied Todar Mal identically everywhere.
- B. No fiscal reconstruction is associated with him.
- C. He created a modern uniform cash-tax state.
- D. Later evidence points to measurement and zabti-type reform, but details need caution.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Source caution matters: later evidence supports a bounded association, not an exact universal clone.

Learning MCQ 9

Jahangir's Deccan policy after 1617 is best described as

- A. recovery with deliberate restraint against deeper annexation.
- B. military impotence without recovery.
- C. total conquest of Bijapur and Golconda.
- D. complete disengagement from the Deccan.

Answer: A.

Explanation: The settlement restored leverage but did not become unlimited conquest.

Learning MCQ 10

Bhaturi (1624) is significant because it

- A. was the treaty that annexed Golconda.
- B. raised Malik Ambar's prestige through a major victory.
- C. marked Shahji's execution.
- D. was the fall of Daulatabad.

Answer: B.

Explanation: Bhaturi belongs to the late high point of Ambar, not to Shah Jahan's Daulatabad phase.

Learning MCQ 11

What ended in 1633?

- A. the whole Deccan question.
- B. Bijapur's independence.
- C. the ruling Nizam Shahi line after Daulatabad's surrender.
- D. Mir Jumla's Karnataka interests.

Answer: C.

Explanation: The dynasty ended in 1633, but resistance and regional competition continued.

Learning MCQ 12

The 1636 settlements are best classified as

- A. direct annexation of Bijapur and Golconda.
- B. equal modern treaties without hierarchy.

- C. a Portuguese-led maritime federation.
- D. coercive Mughal suzerainty that preserved buffer states.

Answer: D.

Explanation: Tribute, khutba change and arbitration indicate hierarchy, while the courts themselves survived.

Learning MCQ 13

Which Golconda feature belongs securely to the 1636 settlement?

- A. the Mughal emperor's name in the khutba under a protection framework.
- B. the abolition of the Qutb Shahi court.
- C. the cession of every port to the Mughals.
- D. the execution of Mir Jumla.

Answer: A.

Explanation: Khutba change signalled superiority; it did not convert Golconda into a Mughal province.

Learning MCQ 14

Aurangzeb's second Deccan viceroyalty belongs to

- A. 1636-44 and the first implementation phase.
- B. 1652-57 and the deficit-strain phase.
- C. 1686-1707 and later imperial annexation.
- D. the years before Akbar's Deccan policy began.

Answer: B.

Explanation: The second viceroyalty is the 1652-57 phase marked by fiscal pressure and intervention.

Learning MCQ 15

Mir Jumla matters in Topic 18 chiefly because

- A. he abolished Mughal suzerainty in 1636.
- B. he was the founder of Ahmadnagar.
- C. his rupture with Golconda opened a new Mughal intervention point in 1656.
- D. he commanded Portuguese cartaz fleets.

Answer: C.

Explanation: His wealth, service shift and Karnataka interests sharpened the Golconda dispute.

Learning MCQ 16

Which final conclusion fits Topic 18 best?

- A. The Deccan was a simple north-south religious war.
- B. Mughal policy was unchanging annexation from start to finish.
- C. By 1657 the Mughals had solved direct-rule costs completely.
- D. Entry, partial control, coalition resistance, treaty and renewed intervention formed one evolving capacity problem.

Answer: D.

Explanation: The topic is best closed as an evolving capacity problem rather than as a single triumphal conquest story.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified/routed 2026 status for Topic 18

- Searched the mandated 2026 official-paper and routing roots listed in the audit brief.
- Checked `books\mains\2026\`, `knowledge-export\Mains PYQ\`, `exams\papers\`, `new_papers\`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-GS1-2026.md`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-GS1-GS3-Static-2026.md`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\_PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md`, `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\PYQ-INTEGRATION-AUDIT-2026.md` and `upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\PYQ-MAINS-COVERAGE-AUDIT-2026.md`.
- Result: **no direct Topic 18-owned 2026 prelims or mains item** on Mughal-Deccan policy to 1657, Ahmadnagar, Chand Bibi, Malik Ambar, the 1636 settlement, Mir Jumla or the 1656-57 Deccan breach was verified locally.

PYQ 1 - UPSC Mains GS-I 2020 (adjacent source-method route)

Paper route evidence: `_PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md` routes 2020 GS-I Q12 - "Persian literary sources of medieval India and the spirit of the age" - to Topic 24. It is retained here as an adjacent support item because Mughal and Deccani Persian chronicles are indispensable source families for Topic 18 answers.

Question: *Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.* (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer: Persian literary sources reflect the spirit of medieval India because they preserve the political language through which courts understood sovereignty, hierarchy and regional rivalry. For the Mughal-Deccan field, Abu'l Fazl helps reveal Akbar's claim to all-India over-lordship; Jahangir's memoirs and Shah Jahan-period chronicles illuminate imperial campaign sequence, diplomatic idiom and the limits of consolidation. On the Deccan side, narratives such as Ferishta preserve rival state perspectives, factional memory and the importance of Berar, Ahmadnagar, Bijapur and Golconda. Read together, these texts show an age shaped not by a simple north-south binary but by competing courts, negotiated suzerainty, service mobility and the political use of history itself. Yet the same sources have clear limits. Mughal chronicles reward victory and hierarchy; Deccani chronicles carry regional patronage and retrospective framing. Therefore Persian literary sources do reflect the spirit of the age, but only when they are read comparatively and with attention to genre, patronage and the distinction between imperial claim and actual control.

Demand decoding: "Comment" requires interpretation, not a list of texts. For Topic 18 use, the answer must connect source value with court ideology, campaign sequence and bias.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Open with what Persian chronicles reveal, then use one Mughal and one Deccani evidentiary strand, and end by separating narrative claim from patronage-driven exaggeration.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: This adjacent route earns marks because it converts source names into a method. It also fits Topic 18 honestly: you are not pretending the item directly belongs to Mughal-Deccan policy, but you are using the exact source family that shapes those answers.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one material counter-check such as forts, khutba/sikka or treaty evidence if extra space allows, so the answer shows how chronicles are tested against non-literary evidence.

PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims GS-I 2024 Q56 (adjacent maritime-context route)

Paper route evidence: `_PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md` routes 2024 Prelims Q56 - "Medieval ruler who allowed the Portuguese a fort at Bhatkal" - to Topic 09. The locally refreshed Topic 09 learner-v2 session preserves the exact official Set-A wording and notes that the official key marks **A = Krishnadevaraya** while the provenance of the Bhatkal-fort wording is discussed with caution.

Question: *Who of the following rulers of medieval India gave permission to the Portuguese to build a fort at Bhatkal?*

- A. Krishnadevaraya
- B. Narasimha Saluva
- C. Muhammad Shah III
- D. Yusuf Adil Shah

Answer: A

Model explanation: The official Set-A key preserved locally marks **A. Krishnadevaraya**. Topic 18 keeps this item only as an adjacent support route because the west-coast and Vijayanagara-Portuguese setting belongs primarily to Topic 09. Its limited value here is contextual: the Deccan was linked to horse trade, coastal commerce and Portuguese pressure, so maritime facts could influence inland statecraft. The careful exam move is to preserve the official answer while also remembering that the exact Bhatkal-fort wording is discussed in the repository with source-provenance caution.

Demand decoding: This is a direct factual prelims question. In Topic 18 it functions only as a bounded reminder that maritime context mattered to Deccan politics.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Eliminate Muhammad Shah III and Yusuf Adil Shah as Deccan-sultanate distractors once the question explicitly asks for the ruler associated with Portuguese Bhatkal permission in the preserved UPSC route. Do not over-extend the fact into a whole essay on Mughal policy.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it preserves official exam routing honestly while keeping ownership boundaries clear. The route earns marks in Topic 18 only when used as supporting coastal context, not as a falsely direct Mughal-Deccan PYQ.

How to improve/strengthen: If you use this fact in a mains answer, immediately relate it back to the horse-trade and western-coast strategic setting instead of leaving it as isolated trivia.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Why did Mughal victory in 1600-01 fail to produce durable control in the Deccan? (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer: Mughal victory in 1600-01 created a serious foothold but not durable Deccan control because fort capture and corridor annexation did not automatically pacify the wider political field. Ahmadnagar fort fell in 1600 and Asirgarh-Khandesh in 1601, giving the empire Berar, a major stronghold and the northern gateway through Burhanpur. Yet a Nizam Shahi remnant survived, and the countryside beyond garrisons remained contested. Malik Ambar later showed how local legitimacy, mobile cavalry, forts and supply disruption could outlast imperial map claims. The deeper limit was administrative and fiscal: assessed authority still needed routes, grain, fodder, local cooperation and revenue realization. Thus the Mughal state won nodes of command, but not the durable integration needed to turn victory into stable Deccan rule.

Demand decoding: The word "why" asks for causes, not a narrative of campaigns alone. The answer must move from victory to limit.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Begin with the exact gains of 1600-01, then explain three limits: remnant legitimacy, logistics and revenue-local cooperation.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because the answer does not stop at "Malik Ambar resisted." It explains structurally why fort victory was insufficient.

How to improve/strengthen: Add Berar and Burhanpur by name if you want sharper geography within the same word limit.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks, 150 words

Question: Explain Chand Bibi's place in Mughal-Deccan relations. (Answer in 150 words)

Model answer: Chand Bibi occupies a central place in Mughal-Deccan relations because she turned regency, fort defence and negotiated compromise into one political strategy. During the Ahmadnagar succession crisis of 1595-96, she backed the infant Bahadur, drew support from important factions and held off the Mughal siege for months. Her significance lies not only in resistance but also in settlement: the 1596 compromise ceded Berar while preserving Bahadur's regency under Mughal suzerainty. This gave the Mughals their first durable foothold without immediately destroying the Nizam Shahi state. Chand Bibi therefore cannot be reduced either to a romantic warrior-queen or to a surrender figure. She exemplifies constrained but active statecraft inside a fragmented Deccan field.

Demand decoding: "Explain" requires role and significance together. A one-dimensional heroic sketch will not be enough.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Use the three anchors: succession crisis -> defence -> Berar settlement and regency survival.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because Chand Bibi is presented as a political actor under constraint, not as a decorative anecdote.

How to improve/strengthen: Mention Habshi backing or Bijapur-Golconda appeal if you want to show the wider coalition setting more clearly.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: Assess Malik Ambar's significance in Mughal-Deccan relations. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Malik Ambar was the single most important intermediary figure between Akbar's incomplete Deccan foothold and Shah Jahan's later reorganisation of the region. His significance began with office and coalition. An Ethiopian or Habshi figure who rose in Deccan service, he became Peshwa of the restored Nizam Shahi regime and tied together dynastic legitimacy, Habshi-Deccani-Afghan manpower, opportunistic Bijapuri support and Maratha bargi mobility. Militarily, he exposed Mughal weakness in terrain, communication and supply. Instead of offering the kind of decisive battle the empire preferred, he relied on movement, harassment, intelligence and the cutting of grain and fodder lines. Administratively, later evidence associates him with measurement and zabti-type agrarian reconstruction; even with source caution, this shows that resistance required fiscal rebuilding, not merely cavalry raiding. His limitations matter too. Mughal recoveries in 1616-17 and 1621, his difficult relations with Bijapur and the eventual extinction of the Nizam Shahi line after his death show that he did not permanently solve the Ahmadnagar problem. His largest historical importance lies in delaying consolidation, revealing the cost of direct rule and deepening the service-military world from which later Maratha power would draw.

Demand decoding: "Assess" needs balanced significance, not hero worship or dismissal.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Move through coalition -> warfare -> revenue -> limitation -> legacy. Keep one sentence for qualification.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because each claim is attached to named evidence and because the answer resists the two easy extremes: permanent saviour or marginal spoiler.

How to improve/strengthen: Add Khirki and Bhaturi if you want sharper evidence of urban capacity and late prestige within the same structure.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks, 250 words

Question: How should the 1636 Deccan settlement be understood: annexation or graded suzerainty? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: The 1636 Deccan settlement should be understood as graded Mughal suzerainty, not as direct annexation of the surviving Deccan sultanates. Shah Jahan had already ended the ruling Nizam Shahi line at Daulatabad in 1633, but he did not extend the same mode of direct incorporation to Bijapur and Golconda. Instead, he created a layered political order. Bijapur accepted Mughal superiority, paid indemnity, came under imperial arbitration in disputes and was bound by conditions relating to Shahji. Golconda accepted protection and hierarchy through tribute and the khutba shift toward Shah Jahan. These markers mattered because they proclaimed superiority without extinguishing the local courts. That is why the settlement can be called statesmanlike: it stabilised the frontier more cheaply than total annexation would have done. Yet "statesmanlike" should not be romanticised. The compact was imposed from a position of force, remained unequal, and depended on continuing capacity and trust. Therefore the most accurate formulation is coercive buffer management under Mughal over-lordship rather than full provincial absorption.

Demand decoding: The binary in the question is the key. You must define both terms before judging the settlement.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Define annexation and suzerainty in the opening line, then assign Bijapur and Golconda evidence to the correct side and close with the cost argument.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it resolves the conceptual distinction clearly instead of mixing symbolic recognition with direct administration.

How to improve/strengthen: Add one sentence on direct Mughal provinces in the northern Deccan if you want to sharpen the contrast between what was annexed and what was subordinated.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Trace the evolution of Mughal Deccan policy from the 1591 missions to the 1636 settlement. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: Mughal Deccan policy evolved from pressure for recognition to selective annexation and finally to graded suzerainty. In 1591 Akbar's missions demanded acceptance of Mughal over-lordship. Khandesh complied, but the major Deccan states did not. The Ahmadnagar succession crisis then opened the way for intervention. Chand Bibi's 1596 compromise preserved Bahadur's regency but ceded Berar, giving the Mughals their first durable foothold. The next stage was harder conquest: Ahmadnagar fort fell in 1600 and Asirgarh-Khandesh in 1601. Yet this did not produce complete control because a Nizam Shahi remnant survived and Malik Ambar reorganised resistance through coalition and mobility. Jahangir's reign therefore mixed recovery with restraint. Mughal victories in 1616-17 and 1621 restored leverage, but the empire still avoided limitless annexation. Shah Jahan hardened policy against Ahmadnagar, using the Khan-i-Jahan Lodi issue, Fath Khan's defection and the siege of Daulatabad to extinguish the ruling Nizam Shahi line in 1633. The final adjustment came in 1636, when Bijapur and Golconda were subordinated without being annexed. Thus Mughal policy moved from embassy to foothold to direct pressure and then to a buffer-state settlement designed to match power with administrative capacity.

Demand decoding: "Trace" needs chronology plus policy shifts. Dates should support transitions, not become a bare list.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Divide the answer into four turns: missions, Akbar's foothold, Jahangir's restrained recovery, Shah Jahan's 1633-36 reordering.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because every stage changes the policy form: diplomacy, foothold, limited recovery and suzerainty settlement.

How to improve/strengthen: Add Burhanpur-Khandesh route logic in the introduction if you want a stronger geographical frame from the first line.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks, 250 words

Question: Analyse the causes and consequences of the breakdown of the 1636 Deccan settlement by 1657. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer: The 1636 Deccan settlement broke down by 1657 because a frontier designed around subordinate buffers came under pressure from fiscal weakness, changing regional opportunity and more demanding Mughal intervention. The original compact had worked by combining direct Mughal control in the northern Deccan with subordinate but surviving courts in Bijapur and Golconda. Over time, however, two strains deepened. First, the Mughal Deccan remained fiscally difficult: assessed income exceeded realisation, and the region could require support from richer northern centres. Second, Bijapur and Golconda expanded into Karnataka and the Coromandel, increasing both their resources and their strategic weight. Aurangzeb's second viceroyalty from 1652 sharpened these tensions. With Murshid Quli Khan, he pressed for revenue improvement and looked more favourably on territorial or indemnity solutions. Mir Jumla's rupture with Golconda in 1656 and the dispute over tribute, exchange and Karnataka wealth created one opening; Muhammad Adil Shah's death and the Bijapur succession crisis created another. The resulting interventions won Ramgir from Golconda and former Nizam Shahi lands from Bijapur, but they also destroyed confidence in the 1636 order. By 1657 the Mughals had reopened the annexation question without resolving the cost of direct rule. That unresolved dilemma forms the immediate background to the later imperial-Deccan wars.

Demand decoding: "Analyse" requires causation and consequence together. Do not stop at the list of 1656-57 events.

Executable answer/elimination plan: Explain the original compact first, then give fiscal and political causes, then show why the outcome was breach rather than finished conquest.

Why this earns marks / route earns marks: It earns marks because it connects event triggers to structural strain and closes at the correct 1657 boundary instead of drifting into the later succession war.

How to improve/strengthen: Add the phrase "suzerainty without annexation" early if you want the contrast with 1656-57 pressure to stand out more sharply.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

1. Sources and evidence limits

Source family	What it helps establish	What it cannot establish by itself
Mughal Persian chronicles	campaign sequence, imperial claims, appointments, diplomatic idiom	literal truth of every victory claim or stable countryside control
Deccan court histories	regional perspective, rival courts, remembered boundaries	neutral non-partisan reporting
Later Marathi records and bakhars	service memory, local offices, fiscal recollection	a perfectly contemporary, uniform seventeenth-century administrative file
Treaties, khutba/sikka, correspondence	formal hierarchy, demands, symbolic recognition	actual compliance, revenue realization or secure local loyalty
Forts, cities, waterworks and coins	route logic, urban capacity, named claims	campaign motives without textual support
European commercial reports	port, textile, horse and coastal information	the whole internal logic of Deccan court politics

2. Historiographical cautions

1. **All-India sovereignty versus expansionism:** policy often preferred subordinate states to direct annexation.
2. **Malik Ambar as defender or destabiliser:** he preserved resistance and trained local service networks, but he also worked through unstable coalition politics.
3. **Jahangir as failure or restraint:** repeated recovery followed by limited settlement is better read as strategic restraint under cost pressure than as simple helplessness.
4. **1636 as statesmanship or coercive pause:** both are true in different registers; the settlement reduced cost precisely because it stopped short of complete direct rule.
5. **1656-57 as Aurangzeb's aggression or Shah Jahan's reversal:** Aurangzeb pressed more expansive remedies, but the emperor's own shifting aims and fiscal needs were also part of the breach.

3. Culture, ports and political economy

- Bijapur and Golconda should be remembered as politically active courts with composite Persianate-Deccani-regional cultures, not as blank military shells.
- The western coast mattered for horse traffic, shipping and Portuguese leverage; the Karnataka-Coromandel zone mattered later for textile, indigo and the Mir Jumla dispute.
- These dimensions enrich Topic 18 only when tied back to court capacity, wealth and rivalry. A full art-and-culture essay belongs elsewhere.

4. High-yield advanced distinctions

- `annexation != suzerainty != protection != arbitration != occupation`
- `fort capture != countryside pacification`
- `khutba/sikka recognition != completed administration`
- `Maratha service bridge != later Maratha sovereign state`
- `1657 breach != later Aurangzeb annexation endgame`

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

The Deccan political field in one page

- Post-Bahmani core for this topic: **Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda**.
- Secondary background only: absorbed Berar, smaller Bidar, and the Faruqi **Khandesh gateway**.
- Topic 18 is not a replay of Topic 09. Use Vijayanagara and Talikota only as bounded context.
- The Deccan is **connected but frictional**: routes mattered, yet monsoon, fodder, forts and local elites made holding the region expensive.
- Opening conceptual distinction: `tribute / protection / suzerainty / occupation / annexation / durable control` are not synonyms.

Chronology spine

- **1576:** Khandesh submits; Burhanpur-Asirgarh corridor becomes more usable.
- **1591:** Akbar's missions seek acceptance of Mughal over-lordship.
- **1595-96:** Ahmadnagar succession crisis; Chand Bibi defends Bahadur's regency; **Berar ceded**.
- **1597:** Deccani effort to recover Berar fails in the Berar theatre.
- **1600:** Ahmadnagar fort falls.
- **1601:** Asirgarh and Khandesh secured; a Nizam Shahi remnant still survives.
- **1610:** Malik Ambar reverses much of the Mughal field position outside secure bases.
- **1616-17 / 1621:** Mughal recoveries under Khan-i-Khanan and Prince Khurram.
- **1624:** Bhaturi marks a late peak of Ambar's prestige.
- **1626:** Malik Ambar dies; one OCR strand prints 1627, so write the standard chronology consciously.
- **1633:** Daulatabad surrenders; ruling Nizam Shahi line ends.
- **1636:** Bijapur and Golconda subordinated through Mughal suzerainty, not annexation.
- **1652-57:** Aurangzeb's second viceroyalty works under deficit pressure.
- **1656-57:** Mir Jumla-Golconda and Bijapur succession crises break the 1636 spirit.

Core answer logic

- Akbar's policy: **gateway + embassy + hierarchy demand + foothold**.
- Chand Bibi: **defence + regency + Berar compromise**, not pure legend.
- 1600-01: serious gain, but **foothold != total control**.
- Malik Ambar: **claimant legitimacy + coalition + movement + supply-cutting + fiscal caution**.
- Jahangir: **recovery with restraint**, not only failure.
- Shah Jahan: **Ahmadnagar extinguished -> buffers preferred**.
- 1636: **coercive suzerainty**.
- 1656-57: **breach of compact under fiscal and political strain**.

Prelims traps

- Khandesh was **not** one of the Bahmani successor states.
- Chand Bibi did **not** permanently end the war; she bought survival through Berar cession.
- Malik Ambar was **Habshi/Nizam Shahi Peshwa**, not a Maratha king.
- "Guerrilla" is a **careful shorthand**, not a modern ideology label.
- Khutba and tribute show **hierarchy**, not guaranteed district-level control.
- 1636 did **not** annex Bijapur and Golconda.
- Topic 18 stops at **1657**, before the later annexation wars.

Mains answer spine

1. Define the Deccan as a connected but frictional political field.
2. Explain Akbar's embassy-to-foothold sequence.
3. Show why 1600-01 fell short of durable consolidation.
4. Use Malik Ambar to explain coalition, mobility and fiscal-local limits.
5. Distinguish Jahangir's restraint from Shah Jahan's 1633-36 restructuring.
6. Define the 1636 settlement as suzerainty without annexation.
7. Close with the 1656-57 breach and stop at 1657.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

TOPIC 18: THE DECCAN & THE MUGHALS (TO 1657)

POST-BAHMANI FIELD
Ahmadnagar + Bijapur + Golconda + Khandesh gateway
-> Deccan connected by routes, trade, service elites and forts
-> yet frictional because monsoon, fodder, distance and local power mattered

AKBAR'S OPENING
Khandesh/Burhanpur/Asirgarh -> gateway secured
1591 missions -> demand for Mughal over-lordship
Khandesh submits; major Deccan courts do not

AHMADNAGAR CRISIS
1595-96 succession struggle
-> Chand Bibi backs infant Bahadur
-> four-month defence
-> Berar ceded under Mughal suzerainty

FOOTHOLD, NOT FINISH
1597 Berar recovery attempt fails
1600 Ahmadnagar fort falls
1601 Asirgarh/Khandesh secured
-> but Nizam Shahi remnant survives
-> conquest on paper still needs countryside control

MALIK AMBAR
Habshi origin -> Nizam Shahi Peshwa
-> claimant legitimacy + coalition + Maratha bargis
-> mobility + intelligence + supply-cutting
-> later evidence of zabti-type reconstruction + Khirki support

WHY CONSOLIDATION FAILED
artillery and forts mattered
but revenue, hasil, fodder, routes and local cooperation mattered too
-> fort victory != durable rule

JAHANGIR PHASE
1610 reversal outside secure bases
1611 failed Mughal coordination
1616-17 / 1621 recoveries under Khan-i-Khanan and Khurram
1624 Bhaturi
-> recovery with restraint, not final annexation

MARATHA SERVICE BRIDGE
deshmukhs + bargis + shifting service ties + Shahji
-> prehistory of later Maratha power
-> not yet the mature Shivaji state

SHAH JAHAN AND AHMADNAGAR
Khan-i-Jahan Lodi asylum sharpens policy
Fath Khan defects
1633 Daulatabad falls; ruling line ends
-> Shahji still sustains claimant resistance

1636 SETTLEMENT
Bijapur -> suzerainty + indemnity + arbitration + Shahji condition
Golconda -> khutba shift + tribute/protection
-> buffer courts survive
-> annexation avoided because cost mattered

1652-57 PRESSURE
Aurangzeb's second viceroyalty + Murshid Quli Khan
-> deficit, weak realization and search for relief
Mir Jumla breaks with Golconda (1656)
Bijapur succession crisis (1656-57)
-> Ramgir and former Nizam Shahi lands taken
-> spirit of 1636 broken

FINAL VERDICT
Topic ends at 1657:
Mughal power moved from embassy to foothold to coalition war to suzerainty settlement to renewed breach.
The unresolved problem was simple to state and hard to solve: how to convert victory into durable, affordable Deccan rule.